UIC Research Journal
Vol. 19 No. 1 April 2013
International Peer Reviewed Faculty Research Journal

Print ISSN 1656 – 0604 • Online ISSN 2244 – 6532
http://dx.doi.org/10.17158/482
Available online at http://research.uic.edu.ph/ojs/

Discourse Analysis of Persuasive Language in Philippine Print Advertising

Edroslyn J. Fernandez
http://orcid.org/0000-0002-1340-806X
efernandez819@yahoo.com
Holy Cross of Davao College

Abstract

This qualitative study employed discourse analysis of persuasive language of 115 print advertisements of beauty products from one year issue of three local magazines. Thorough data analysis showed that persuasive language of print advertising is embedded in indirect convincing through an appeal to emotional needs, an appeal to celebrity image, and an appeal to colonial mentality of consumers. Furthermore, persuasive language is embedded in analogy through the use of metaphor and future events. Results also showed that the syntactic and semantic features of print advertising in Philippine context include the use of adjectives, time expressions, figurative language, clipping, blending, poetic devices, imperatives, code-switching, and problem-solution structure. An interesting social issue generated from the result of the study is the myth of women's agelessness and perfection.It is recommended that a similar study be conducted to radio and television advertising to improve the practice of advertising language that is reflective of culture, behavior, and educational practices.

Keywords: Advertising, discourse analysis, persuasive language, print advertising, Philippines

Introduction

My years of using beauty products considering my limited budget, and my criteria for economical but quality products have taught me to pay attention to product information by reading the product's manufacturing details, net content, ingredients, and it's "too good to be true" promises. Ironically, even with this knowledge of "too good to be true promises" from product advertisements, I would still end up buying the product, hoping that this newfound product would fulfill its promise. With such dominant power on me, I came to assume that there must be something so influential in the language used by advertising to be able to convince me to buy a particular product.

The idea of Wolfram (2012) who pointed out that language is powerful, gave me initial understanding of the language of advertising. He explained that it is through language, that we are able to send and receive messages which allow comprehensive communication. He further said that language represents social behavior which makes it possible to study how we use language to express ourselves and how our use of language reflects our cultural orientation and goals of interaction.

With much of the language we use today being produced and reflected by mass media, it is appropriate to explore the language of advertising. As discussed by Bechman and Stehr (2011), mass media do not represent an image of reality that they have distinguished, but rather they themselves create the reality which they communicate as daily news, reports, and advertising.

With advertising being a leading component of mass media, it possesses an influential ability to affect human decisions especially in terms of buying and using a product. Based on my personal observation, the most widely used products are those that are most widely advertized. This power of advertising has not only aroused my interest but also that of language or advertising researcher. This interest created an opportunity for linguists to study the language of advertising with the aim of exploring its many facets.

Okazaki, Mueller, and Taylor (2010) have identified advertising language as direct and indirect selling. They described direct selling as hard-

sell advertising which aims to induce rational thinking on the part of the receiver. These appeals tend to be directing, emphasizing a sales orientation and often specifying brand name and recommending product. Often, with this type of advertising, there is explicit mention of factual information, such as comparisons with competing products or specific distinguishing features of the product that gave it an advantage in performance or some other dimension relevant to the consumer. On the other hand, they described indirect selling as soft-sell in which human emotions are emphasized to induce affective reaction from the viewer. This appeal tends to be subtle and indirect and an image or atmosphere may be conveyed through a beautiful scene or the development of an emotional story via some other indirect mechanism.

Similarly, Simpson (2001) as cited by Kim (2007) in her study on American magazine advertising. According to Kim, Simpson suggests two main types of advertising discourse. They are reason and tickle, where reason advertising attempts to persuade the consumer by making direct and easy to decipher reference to motive or reason for the purchase, whereas tickle advertising takes more oblique, indirect approach by appealing to humor, emotion, and mood.

Vasiloaia (2009) on the other hand, explored the linguistic features of advertising. Accordingly, the ultimate aim of advertising which is to sell has consequence on the language used to achieve those aim. She specified that advertising language often uses the techniques similar to those in poetic texts. Further, she identified these language features as rhyme, rhythm, alliteration, assonance, graphic aspect of the text, and transliteration.

Objective of the Study

This study aimed to describe the semantic and syntactic persuasion and features of print advertising. It also seeks to know effect how the structure of persuasive language is embedded in Philippine print advertising. Furthermore its objective was to know the syntactic and semantic features of print advertising and the social issue that it could generate.

Method

This study analyzed one year monthly issue of three local magazine brands. According to Lacy, Riffe, and Randle (1998) as cited by Kim (2007), from the field of journalism and mass media studies, and for the purpose of studying the content of a single year, and to include the seasonal publishing cycle, one should conduct a census of all twelve monthly issues in the year.

The three local magazines used for this study are Women's Journal, MOD, and Woman Today, which are published and distributed in the Philippines. These magazines were chosen because they contain advertisements for beauty products and are easily accessible. Furthermore, their target readers are women in the Philippines.

Specifically, I utilized the print advertising of beauty products. Examples of these beauty products are cosmetics, lotion, conditioner, whitening products and beauty spa. The choice to focus on beauty products is due to the fact that they are much more difficult to market compared with essential goods and thus, require a more persuasive strategy. Included in my analysis are all print advertisements including feature advertisements in the three magazines, regardless of their length and space occupied. Any repeated advertisements appearing in the same magazine in a later issue or in a different magazine were excluded from the analysis.

Due to the nature of the study which employed discourse analysis of print advertisement, my primary role was to gather, read, and compile the print advertisements from the three magazines chosen for this study. I started by obtaining a copy of all twelve issues of Woman Today, MOD, and Woman's Journal. Then I encoded each advertisement's texts, made a lay-out for coding, and then printed it before I started the coding process. Then I employed the manual analysis of advertisements based on my theoretical lens.

Results and Discussion

Structure of persuasive language embedded in print advertising

Indirect Convincing: Appeal to Emotional Needs. The January 2012 issue of Woman Today contains feature advertisement of a make-up. The

advertisement begins by greeting the readers a Happy New Year and then proceeds to talk about how one should have a fresh start by giving friendly advice on clothing, hairstyle and make-up.

The advertisement attempts to establish a more personal approach by appealing to the consumer's emotional need for confidence and self-esteem. In Maslow's hierarchy of needs, confidence belongs to higher level of needs which are emotional rather than physical. It is making claims of the attributes that are related to the advertized product. These attributes, as mentioned is the advertisement, are crowning glory, sense of style, and people's attention, but different from the intended attribute of the advertised product which is physical enhancement. This enabled the advertisement to appeal to consumers need for self-esteem, through appreciation of physical attribute as enhanced by make-up application. The advertisement also offers advice to women who do not know much about make-up and make-up application. It stimulates interest of women who are used to applying make-up as part of their daily regimen.

In another make-up advertisement, a celebrity first shares her experience during her first date, an experience that most teens can relate to and dreamed of. In her informal and friendly tone, she talked about common teenage problems as sweating and oily skin. Reading this advertisement, most teenagers will find themselves able to relate to the advertisement as most teens targeted by this advertisement have experienced or about to experience their first date. Knowing that someone is also experiencing or have experienced the same problem that one is going through is very reassuring, much more if that person is a celebrity. This gives the consumer a feeling of confidence in herself and trust on the product being endorsed by alleviating that feeling of insecurity through the use of the product endorsed. Thus, in this world where women are judged by their appearance and agelessness (Ellison, 2010), an advertisement that offers ways and means to looking young and beautiful through its make-up tutorials and line of beauty products prove to be much effective as it soothes insecurities and boosts self-esteem.

Indirect Convincing: Appeal to an Image. Another example of indirect convincing is the frequent use of famous-person testimonial, whereby

a product is endorsed by a well-known person. In one advertisement, the product is linked with a TV host/model known for elegance and fair skin due to her Korean origin. The current popularity of this celebrity makes it easy for consumers to remember her and the brand she is associated with.

Rockler-Gladen (2008) described that association technique involves drawing a mental link between a product and desirable qualities of various kinds that may include attractiveness, wealth, success, family, patriotism, or security. In this particular advertisement, its aim is to draw a mental link between the product and the endorser's image of elegance.

The use of association in advertising is implicit and indirect because it appeals to the consumers' desire to have the same quality as the person the product is being associated with. As Okazaki, Mueller and Taylor (2010) puts it, indirect persuasion builds on the image of the product.

With this, persuasion is embedded in the advertisement through an appeal to consumer's deep-seated nonmarket desire such as elegance and being celebrity-like by building the product image. This type of advertising succeeds because even though the product really has nothing or little to do with the person or concept it is associated with it gives consumers some psychic benefits.

Indirect Convincing: Appeal to Colonial Mentality. Another example of indirect convincing is an appeal to our sense of security through our Filipino colonial mentality. Gabornes (2013) cited David and Okazaki's (2006) conceptualization of colonial mentality among Filipinos and Filipino Americans as a form of internalized oppression, characterized by a perception of ethnic or cultural inferiority. It involves an automatic and unreasonable rejection of anything Filipino and an instinctive and uncritical preference for anything Western or foreign. This type of mentality has been used by advertisers in their persuasive campaign.

Persuasion is embedded in words and phrases like US-made, export quality, and world class, which are very attractive to Filipino consumers, because it gives a sense of security, satisfaction, and assurance in terms of product quality. These words and phrases focus on the image of the product making it direct rather than indirect selling.

Analogy: Metaphor. Analogy is another method of persuasion used by many advertisers because it stimulates thinking and promotes curiosity about the product advertized many advertisers use this method in promoting their products. In the print advertisements gathered for this paper, analogy is presented in the form of metaphor. Metaphors are highly used in print advertising to stimulate analogy and to simplify things that are otherwise hard to understand.With the use of appropriate signs, words, and symbols as representations, metaphors have the ability to activate dormant emotional responses or create such emotional responses if they are absent (Zaltman & Rockler-Gladen, 2007).

It is important to point out that metaphors have the ability to result to a lot of meaning which are most of the time favorable to advertisers but not to consumers. With metaphors, consumers are free to give their interpretation based on their own needs and desires and although those needs and desires are not met by the product, the advertisers are not at all liable because metaphors have no direct, literal claim. Thus, because of metaphors' ability to induce responses like feelings like joy, fear, surprise, anticipation, and sadness, they are able to stimulate consumers' responses and persuade them to buy and use the product represented by the metaphor.

For the purpose of this paper, metaphor is defined as the representation of one thing in terms of another. In this advertisement, a metaphor is used to represent the benefit of the product. Thus, looking and feeling young is represented by an anti-aging and whitening facial cream. This anti-aging whitening cream appeals to consumers' nonmarket desire which is to look and feel young. Because almost every woman, including myself, seems to want to look and feel young, this metaphor is very attractive.

Analogy: Atmosphere of Future Events. Spears (2003) asserts that time is closely related to life, to language, and to purchase. Society is increasingly concerned with time and time plays a key role in the consumption process. From this tradition flows the linkage between expressions of time and the promotion of product benefits. Advertisements use time expressions to prompt consumers to consider future events, such as the consumption and enjoyment of desired product benefits put forth in an advertisement.

In an anti-aging beauty product, its advertisement presents prefiguration of the things to come, such as growing old and losing that youthful appearance. With the use of figurative time expression, the consumer is being prompted to take action as early as the present. This advertisement is effective because it moves a person to take action in order to preserve her present appearance and hopefully avoid or extend future wrinkling of the skin.

Such sense of urgency has the ability to prompt consumers to take action. Spears (2003) has pointed out that perceptions of the delay of promised product benefits can generate more immediate action. Given this example, it is evident how advertisers take advantage of the use of figurative time expressions in selling their product. The persuasive effect of time expressions is embedded in its ability to build an atmosphere of future events through delayed promises, prompting consumers to take immediate action.

Syntactic and semantic features of print advertising

Use of Adjectives. The most common forms of adjectives used in print advertising are absolute and superlative adjectives because they indicate the highest degree. They are used to project an image of having everything that a consumer expects from the product. They establish that the product is above other brand counterpart. Most common absolute adjectives in print advertising are perfect, original, best, and natural. Also, the most common superlatives are best, latest, most beautiful, gentlest, and freshest. Because generally consumers want the best product there is, these forms are obviously meant both to attract the consumers and to convince the readers that the advertised product is better than competitor's counterpart.

Use of Time Expressions: Literal and Figurative. Time is used by advertisers to convey product benefits. Literal time expressions are definite. They have exact time. With literal time expressions, the consumer will know what to expect at an exact time as indicated in the advertisement. One advertisement of whitening lotion explains that when the consumer uses the product, she can already expect lightening of her skin complexion in one week time. This makes the consumer feel much better that the product bought

will indeed give immediate result. Literal time expression is also helpful in establishing product commitment. By giving itself a due date, consumers feel that the product is truly committed in fulfilling its promise. Otherwise, it would not have set a deadline for itself.

In contrast to literal time expressions, advertisements also utilize figurative time expressions. Figurative time expressions avoid commitment to an exact meaning because they are indirect in interpretation and understanding. This type of time expressions does not convey functional benefits. Instead, its promise relies on psychosocial benefits. Thus, this saves the advertisement any liability in case the product promise is not fulfilled.

One cologne advertisement implies that its scent will last longer. But it is not clear as to how long. This type of figurative expression could generate a lot of meaning. It could mean that the scent will last longer than one's present brand, or longer than other colognes. If in case the cologne does not last longer than expected, the advertisement could not be blamed for misinterpretation.

Hence, the use of literal time expression satisfies consumers' desire for immediate result, while the use of figurative time expression allows the consumers to anticipate results at their most convenient time.

Use of Conjunctive Adjuncts: Causal and Purposive. Conjunctive adjuncts are used to characterize reason advertising. There are five types of conjunctive adjuncts. However, the print advertisements in the magazines I analyzed for this study reflect only two types of conjunctive adjuncts. They are purposive and causal.

Purposive adjuncts are characterized by the use of in order to, so that you can, to + verb and for. They are used to state purpose and benefit of the product. The advertisement using purposive adjunct can show product benefits. By using to + verb as in to lighten, the advertisement was able to make clear its benefits.

On the other hand, causal adjuncts are characterize by so, then, because, as a result, and that's why. In this paper, the most common form of causal advertisement are for and because. Just like purposive adjuncts,

causal advertisement is a reason advertisement in the form of giving reason for product purchase.

Use of Figurative Language: Hyperbole, Metaphor, Simile, and Punning. Although there are many types of figurative language, only hyperbole, metaphor, simile, and punning were observed in this study.

Hyperbole is an exaggeration utilized with the obvious intent of persuasion. It works in advertising. One advertisement claims to be the World's No.1. For a product to claim that it is World's No. 1 is an exaggeration much more if it is only sold in the local market. The play of words in exaggeration is catchy and although its claims are not realistic, the thought of realizing the impossible and unachievable gives comfort.

Another figurative language used in advertising is simile. In advertising, simile is used to compare the product with another in order to make vivid product benefits. One skin lightening product compares its affordability to a dream come true. By this comparison, the advertisement is able to express that skin whitening is not anymore just a dream because with the use of the product, having whiter skin can be achievable. Second, the product is compared with a celebrity. With similes, it is easier for consumer to have a vivid idea of the product's benefits. If consumers know what the product can do and if they understand the product benefits, it is easier for them to trust the product and trust is an important quality in order to convince consumers to buy the product.

Metaphor is also used in advertising.There is vast literature that defines metaphor. In advertising, metaphors are widely use. Holman and Harmon (2008) describes metaphor as an implied analogy identifying one object with another and ascribing to the first with emotional or imaginative qualities associated with the second.

A hair cream advertisement is being identified with softer, bouncier, and shinier hair. This metaphor aims to build a favorable image of the product. Tuan (2010) asserts that one of the advantages of metaphor is its centrality to the process of imagination. He added that without metaphors, we cannot imagine. Metaphors are the engines of imagination. Identifying the brand with soft, shiny, and bouncy hair prompts consumers to go to the

supermarket and buy the hair cream. Such form of association stimulates the consumer's imagination to visualize having an almost perfect hair.

The cosmetic advertisement also employs pun or a play of words to express different sense of the same word or on the similar sense or sound of different words. It consists of deliberately confusing similar words or phrases for rhetorical effect and playing with the several possible meanings that many words have (Krishnasamy, 2007). For example, one advertisement says Beauty can't be spelled without U, where U refers to letter u and pronoun you. With this, memorability is enhanced. The more the line resonates with the big idea, the more memorable it will be and memorability is an important factor in selling a product.

Use of Clipping. Kosur (2012) defined clipping as a word formation process in which a word is reduced or shortened without changing the meaning of the word. Examples of clipped word in Philippine print advertisement are fab, for fabulous, lipo for liposuction, and detox for detoxify. Clipping is used because consumers are more familiar with the clipped word rather than its original version. This type of word formation is not only popular in print advertising but in television advertising as well due to its memorability.

Use of Blending. In blending, two words are merged. In scentsational a cologne advertisement combines scent and sensation. Another example comes from a lipstick advertisement which blends pretty and delicious in prettylicious. These blended words add attraction to the advertisement because they are new and they sound interesting and enticing and not only concerned with the process that expands the vocabulary of a language but also with the ability to attract attention and eventually sell products.

Words formed out of clipping and blending are both new and memorable. These words have a special meaning in the specified context. Consumers find that these kinds of words can raise the interests of the advertisement receivers, and can make them ponder upon the meaning and marvel at the smart idea of the advertisement message. By so doing, they easily recognize the brand. And by recognizing the brand, they are able to put trust in it and end up buying the brand.

Use of Poetic Devices: Alliteration and Rhyme. Because alliteration and rhyme have something to do with the ability the line has to be recalled unaided, they are observed in Philippine print advertising. They largely help in making the target consumer easily remember the product. The summer issue of cosmetic advertising has a tagline of Beat and heat. By this, the brand name is highlighted. Also, it can differentiate a product from others by the brand name and the special rhyming which is the identity of the advertisement.

Use of Imperatives. With the use of imperatives, advertisers are able to use every opportunity to exhort the potential customers to act, to buy and to consume as with the sentence "Try it to believe it" from a slimming company. The imperative is their last battle field to get people moved. It is not surprising that advertisers would use imperative sentences in advertising. This kind of sentence is the most direct way to achieve the ideal effect which is to get the consumer to go and buy the product advertised. The use of verbs try, use, change, and raise as seen in some print advertising, all command the potential consumer to do something. It urges them to act now by expressing urgency.

Use of Code–switching. Media recognizes the importance of the language and dialects we speak. In the Philippines, people equate English with prestige and social status. In effect, dropping of English words seem to add to the persuasive effect of advertisement. With code-switching, the advertisement can be both local and global. A skin care lotion promotes its product by saying Siguradongmas confident pag pimple free at blemish free. The local language identifies with the target consumer, while the international language creates an image of excellent quality. With such quality of code-switching, it is able to establish close connection with local consumers and at the same time giving the impression of being world class.

Use of Problem-Solution Structure. In a whitening and firming advertisement, a problem is presented, followed by a solution. First the advertisement points out to the high price of whitening products as a problem

and then offers its product as a solution. Kim (2007) explains that this kind of structure leads the consumers to accept that some situation presents a problem in their lives. A solution is then presented and justified in the form of the product. Thus, advertisers create a problem in order to market their product. Having fairer-skin and sexier body is not really a problem if we think about it. However, as has been said earlier, advertisers will write anything that will help them sell their products.

The use of these syntactic and semantic features aim to come up with the most effective and efficient advertisement which will ensure product sales. They are varied and innovative. Print advertising will exploit all language forms and features available in order to come up with the most convincing statement. The syntactic and semantic features of print advertising all contribute greatly to the effectiveness and success of print advertisements as evident in Philippine cosmetic print advertising.

Social issues in Philippine print advertising

The Myth of Perfection. At first I thought that the social issue that I would be able to explore in this paper was how women are portrayed as sex objects in print advertising. However, as I continue to delve in the features of print advertising, I realize a more disturbing issue of the myth of perfection as dictated by the beauty advertising. The cosmetic industry spent billions of dollars in research and advertising and profits even more from the exploitation of women's self-esteem and self-image. They promote products that claim to give the perfect hair, perfect skin, perfect body, and even perfect vagina.

Weusten (2009) expressed her concern at how the beauty industry dictates a normative and one-sided idea of female beauty which is young, thin, and sexy. We have witnessed how images of women in advertisements and glossy magazines are manipulated through Photoshop. She criticizes these unrealistic images because they set unattainable norm for every woman. Moreover, she links these unrealistic representations to body-altering practices in commercial for cosmetic surgery.

In the Philippines, the sale of whitening products continues to flourish, from the cheap whitening soap to the unbelievably expensive Glutathione injectable. Indeed, the quest for beauty and perfection is making money at the expense of women's self-image. This calls for an urgent need to educate women about real beauty and the real cause of low self-image.

The Myth of Agelessness. As I gather cosmetics advertisements for this study, I have lost track of the many times I have encountered the prefix anti as used in anti-aging, anti-wrinkles, and anti-age spots. Observably, the cosmetic industry promises rejuvenation, repair, and eternal youthfulness to potential consumers by exposing women to artificial sense of beauty with medically-enhanced models who have become icons of the so-called ageless beauty. It is indeed very interesting how the anti-aging industry of surgical and non-surgical cosmetics has grown to become a multi-billion dollar industry both here and abroad.

Today, it is sad to realize that society looks at age almost as a disease. Even sadder is the effect of aging to women's self-image. Age is not a disease as advertisements seem to display. Age is not equivalent to ugliness as seemed to be portrayed by advertisements with their young, sexy and westernized models.

With this, the contribution of advertising to the distorted concept of women's image of perfection and agelessness is undeniable and requires immediate attention.

Literature Cited

Bechmann, G. and Stehr, N. 2011. NiklaLuhman's theory of mass media. Retrieved 16 July 2012 from http://search.proquest.com/docview/852338243?accountid=33462

Ellison, K. 2010. The myth of agelessness: A critical discourse analysis of agelessness in North American anti-aging skin care advertisements. Retrieved 9 November 2012, from http://j11.cgpublisher.com/proposals/72/index_html

Gabornes M.C. 2013. Colonial mentality: a Filipino heritage? Retrieved 3 January 2012 from http://pt.scribd.com/doc/34624029/Colonial-Mentality-among-Filipinos

Holman, H. & Harmon, W. 2008. A handbook to literature.Pearson Merill Prentice Hall.

Journal of Advertising, 32 (2), 33-43. Retrieved 9 November 2012, from http://search.proquest.com/docview/236569350/fulltextPDF/13A4941D9F6 6B230830/8?accountid=33462

Kim, M. 2007. Discourse feature and marketing strategy in American magazine advertising. Retrieved 20 July 2012 from http://studentorgs.utexas.edu/salsa/proceedings/2007/Kim.pdf

Krishnasamy, K. 2007. English in Tamil: The language of advertising. Retrieved 16 December 2012. from http://search.proquest.com/docview/205252891/fulltextPDF/13A4949753E7D763E91/8?accountid=33462

Kosur, H. M. 2012. Word formation: compounding, blending, clipping. Retrieved 16 January 2012 from http://www.brighthubeducation.com/esl-lesson- plans/59679-forming- new-words-compounds-clipping-and-blends/

Okazaki, S., Mueller, B., and Taylor, C. 2010. Measuring soft-sell versus hard-sell advertising appeals. Journal of Advertising, 39 (2), pp. 5-20.

Rockler-Gladen, N. 2008. Advertising and persuasive strategy. Retrieved 03 January 2013, from http://suite101.com/article/advertising-persuasion- techniques- a52647#ixzz2GsavVn40

Spears, N. 2003. On the use of time expressions in promoting product benefits.

Tuan, L.T. 2010. Metaphors in advertising discourse. Studies in Literature and Language, 1 (6), pp.75-81.

Weusten, J. 2009. Unraveling the mechanisms of the beauty industry. Transformations 19, (2), pp.129-136.

Vasiloaia, M. 2009. Linguistic features on the language of advertising. Economy Transdisciplinarity Cognition 1, pp 294-298. Retrieved 05 October 2012 from http://search.proquest.com/docview/845590429?accountid=33462

Wolfram, W. 2012. Sociolinguistics.Linguistic Society of America.Retieved July 10, 2012 from http://www.lsadc.org/infro/ling-fields-socio.cfm

Zaltman, G. &Rockler-Gladen, N. 2007. Metaphor in Advertising. Retrieved 3 January 2012 from http://www.omnilogos.com/2011/11/12/metaphor-in- advertising/